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Pokhran: How to Untie a Knot from the Tiger's Neck

Our nuclear *pas de deux* with the Chinese began several decades before India conducted five nuclear tests at Pokhran in the Rajasthan desert in May 1998.

Mao's desire to have a nuclear bomb was not a secret. In April 1956, Mao Zedong had told an enlarged meeting of the Politburo that 'in today's world if we don't want to be bullied, we have to have this thing (nuclear bomb)'. [1] By September 1960, when it had become amply clear to the Chinese Communists, especially following a conversation between Soviet ideologue Mikhail Suslov and Deng Xiaoping, that the Soviets had no intention of assisting the Chinese nuclear programme, [2] Mao decided to go it alone. He secured the services of Qian Xuesen, a Chinese scientist who had studied in America and gone on to be a part of the Manhattan Project (the US nuclear weapons experimental project during the Second World War). Qian was, thus, uniquely placed to steer the Chinese nuclear programme when he returned to the country